Tim Berners-Lee – The Father of the World Wide Web

Biography

Sir Tim Berners-Lee was born on 8 June 1955 in **London, England**, into a family deeply involved in the world of computing. Both of his parents worked on the **Ferranti Mark 1**, one of the earliest commercial computers, which strongly influenced his early fascination with **technology** and **information systems**.

He studied **Physics** at **The Queen's College, Oxford**, where he developed his interest in **computing**. During his time at university, he built his own computer using spare parts, demonstrating an early talent for **engineering** and **programming**.

After graduating, Berners-Lee worked in several technology-related roles before joining **CERN (European Organization for Nuclear Research)** in **Geneva**. It was here, in 1989, that he proposed a revolutionary idea: a system that would allow researchers to easily share and access **information across different computers**. This proposal led to the creation of the **World Wide Web**.

In 1991, he launched the **first website in history**, making the web publicly accessible. Crucially, he decided **not to patent** his invention, allowing it to remain **free and open**, which played a fundamental role in its global success.

Later, he founded the **World Wide Web Consortium (W3C)**, an international organisation dedicated to developing **web standards** and ensuring the long-term growth of the web.

The Invention of the World Wide Web

The **World Wide Web** is built on three essential technologies that remain fundamental today:

- **HTML (HyperText Markup Language)**: used to **structure and create web pages**
- **HTTP (HyperText Transfer Protocol)**: enables **communication between browsers and servers**
- **URL (Uniform Resource Locator)**: provides a **unique address for each resource**

These technologies made it possible to connect and navigate information in a **simple**, **efficient**, and **universal** way.

The **first website**, published on **6 August 1991**, explained how the web worked and how users could create their own pages. It was hosted on a **NeXT computer** at CERN and marked the beginning of a new era in **digital communication**.

It is important to distinguish between the **Internet** and the **World Wide Web**. The Internet is the **global network infrastructure**, while the web is a **service built on top of it**, allowing users to access information through **web browsers**.

Why He Is a Key Figure

Tim Berners-Lee is considered one of the most influential figures in **modern history** because his invention fundamentally changed how people **communicate**, **learn**, and **share knowledge**.

His decision to keep the web **open and decentralised** allowed anyone to contribute, leading to rapid global expansion. Today, billions of people rely on the web for:

- **Education**
- **Business and e-commerce**
- **Social interaction**
- **Scientific research**
- **Entertainment**

Berners-Lee continues to advocate for a better web, focusing on **digital rights**, **privacy**, and **freedom of information**. Through initiatives like the **World Wide Web Foundation**, he works to ensure that the web remains a **public good** accessible to everyone.

He has also been involved in projects promoting **data ownership** and **decentralisation**, such as the **Solid project**, which aims to give users more control over their personal data.

Curiosities and Impact

- He was knighted in 2004, becoming **Sir Tim Berners-Lee**
- He received the **Turing Award (2016)**, often called the “Nobel Prize of Computing”
- He was included in **Time Magazine’s list of the most influential people**
- The first web browser he created was called **WorldWideWeb** (later renamed Nexus)

His invention has had a profound impact on **everyday life**, enabling:

- **Online banking and shopping**
- **Social media platforms**
- **Remote work and education**
- **Instant global communication**

Without the web, modern society would lack the level of **connectivity** and **information access** we often take for granted.

Legacy and Future Vision

Berners-Lee’s work continues to shape the future of the web. He has expressed concerns about issues such as:

- **Misinformation**
- **Loss of privacy**
- **Centralisation of power in big tech companies**

He advocates for a web that is:

- **Open**
- **Accessible**
- **Secure**
- **Respectful of user rights**

His vision is to restore the web as a platform that benefits **humanity as a whole**, rather than just corporations or governments.

Quote

> **“The web is more a social creation than a technical one.”**
> — Tim Berners-Lee